armoured vehicles were also on offer, so were co-production of munitions and equipment, signalling that defence ties can go beyond a buyer-seller relationship.

Dr Harsh Pant, vice president, Observer Research Foundation, says the biggest takeaway from Vance's visit was that India and the US remain committed at the highest levels not only to concluding an early trade agreement but also to using that emblematically to foster bilateral ties. Vance, he tells INDIA TODAY, has signalled that "India will continue to play a very important role in the foreign policy matrix of the Trump administration".

Vance arrived in New Delhi with his family on April 21, and toured popular destinations in Jaipur, Agra, and Delhi over the next few days. Vadluru village in Andhra Pradesh's East Godavari district is the ancestral village of the VP's wife, Usha Vance. But despite the personal flavour, Vance's visit involved significant behind-the-scenes diplomacy—it comes weeks after that of the US Director of National Intelligence, Tulsi Gabbard, for a geopolitical conference.

Vance's focus in Jaipur on sectors like data centres, pharmaceuticals and undersea cables also signals a targeted approach to deepen economic interdependence in critical tech-driven industries. India's data centre market is projected to grow from $6 billion (Rs 51,306 crore) in 2023 to $10 billion (Rs 85,510 crore) by 2028 and US tech giants like Amazon, Google and Microsoft are investing in the infrastructure. Both nations also collaborate on semiconductors et al in the Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technologies (iCET). Also, the US seeks to diversify its pharmaceutical supply chain away from China, and Indian pharma—which supplies 40 per cent of the US generic drugs market—is a natural investment destination.

Vance's upbeat comments—like "India-US ties will shape the 21st century"—were tempered by hard business sense. But the frostiness in ties in the last phase of the Joe Biden presidency (post the assassination attempt on Khalistani leader Gurpatwant Singh Pannun) is clearly dispelled. Now for both sides to make it count in a stable, mutually profitable way. ■

KERALA

Pinarayi's Man Under Scanner

By Jeemon Jacob

Kerala chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan's favoured bureaucrats just can't seem to stay out of trouble. After the gold smuggling through diplomatic channels racket that landed his ex-principal secretary M. Sivasankar in jail in an Enforcement Directorate (ED) case in 2020, it's the turn of K.M. Abraham, the 66-year-old retiree redrafted as Pinarayi's chief principal secretary and CEO of the Kerala Infrastructure Investment Fund Board, to face the heat.

The Kerala High Court has directed the CBI to register a disproportionate assets case against the former chief secretary. The 1982 batch IAS officer is perhaps known more for his 2008-11 tenure in the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), where he was instrumental in investigating the alleged fraudulent dealings of Sahara Parivar Ltd and indicting its chief, Subrata Roy.

Now he stands accused in a case filed by self-styled public crusader Jomon Puthenpurackal. The HC order states that, prima facie, "there are enough materials on record to register an FIR" against Abraham. The petitioner's case rests on three properties in the accused's name that are alleged to be beyond his known sources of income—a flat in Thiruvananthapuram now said to be worth Rs 1 crore, another apartment in Mumbai claimed to

ON YOUR MARKS CM Pinarayi Vijayan presents a T-shirt to his chief principal secretary K.M. Abraham (left) at a sports event

